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# Understanding luxury shaming: a multi-study exploration using qualitative inquiry and generative AI

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ABSTRACT

This research investigates luxury shaming—the social act of assigning negative judgment or disapproval to individuals who engage in luxury consumption. We explore how consumers shame others, and how shamed consumers experience, feel, and cope with such judgments. Methodologically, we integrate traditional qualitative techniques and innovative Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) analysis. Results reveal that luxury shaming is enacted through distinct shaming categories found in the marketplace—intellectual, economic, socio-cultural, physical/aesthetic, and ethical/moral—and triggers emotional responses ranging from embarrassment to guilt and anxiety. Furthermore, we identify three bipolar coping dimensions—stylistic, social-interactive, and value-related—each encompassing two distinct strategies that consumers use to maintain engagement with luxury consumption. Key contributions include expanding the luxury consumption literature by examining its negative consequences, advancing the understanding of shaming-related emotions in consumer behavior, and, methodologically, demonstrating GenAI's role in complementing qualitative analysis.

## 1. Introduction

Recent headlines across global media platforms have highlighted a growing phenomenon impacting the luxury industry, brands, and consumers: "luxury shaming." An article on Medium (June 2024), a social publishing platform, provocatively asks readers, "Luxury shaming: are you being judged for your taste?" Luxury Tribune (July 2024) warns of "Blame and shame in luxury consumption," while Jing Daily (September 2024), the leading digital publication on luxury in China, observes, "The concept of 'luxury shaming' is gaining traction, as overt displays of wealth become less socially acceptable amid economic headwinds." Most importantly, the 2024 Bain & Company luxury market report, arguably the most important annual trade publication on luxury, highlights the resurgence of "luxury shame," as consumers increasingly prefer discreet luxury products over overtly branded items (D'Arpizio & Levato, 2024).

In this paper, we address the phenomenon of "luxury shaming," defining it as *the social act of assigning negative judgment or disapproval to individuals who engage in luxury consumption*. Central to luxury shaming are two interactive roles: those who shame others ("shamers") and the ones who are shamed by others ("the shamed"). We argue that both the actions of shamers and responses of the shamed unfold within a broader performative marketplace. While research has examined the symbolic, identity and competence-related positive aspects of luxury consumption (Han et al., 2010; Pandelaere & Shrum, 2020; Wang, 2022), relatively little attention has been given to the negative discourse on luxury as well as the negative judgments and social backlash that luxury consumers may face, the emotional consequences of such backlash, and the strategies luxury consumers use to cope with it.

To address this gap, we investigate three interrelated research questions: (1) How is luxury shaming expressed in marketplace discourse? (2) How do shamers draw on the content of that discourse to shame others? (3) How do shamed consumers experience, cope with, and respond to luxury shaming? Study 1 examines marketplace discourse on luxury shaming through a thematic content analysis of negative commentary about the industry, brands, and consumption practices to identify content categories that might be used as part of consumer judgments. Next, we present two consumer studies: Study 2 investigates how individuals shame others for their luxury purchases and how luxury consumers experience such shaming; and Study 3 examines the coping strategies that consumers adopt. Finally, Study 4 employs a simulation to validate prior qualitative insights and shows

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that they are consequential and relevant.

Our methodology combines traditional qualitative techniques with innovative Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) analysis, using ChatGPT and NotebookLM. We begin with a ChatGPT analysis of the shaming discourse in the marketplace. Next, we collect qualitative consumer data and iteratively analyze them, employing both standard interpretive methods and GenAI tools. Finally, in a simulated experiment based on the qualitative data, we generate luxury "personae" using GenAI to validate consumer responses to shaming. Together, these studies offer an exploratory, multi-method investigation of this neglected topic within the dark side of luxury.

This research makes several contributions. First, it expands the luxury consumption literature—historically focused on its positive aspects, such as status signaling, identity expression, or competence display, by examining the negative social and emotional ramifications of luxury purchases. Second, it advances understanding of the psychology of luxury shaming, including experiences and feelings of shame and guilt. Finally, methodologically, the research demonstrates how GenAI can enhance efficiency, insight, and depth in qualitative and cultural research, paving the way for new methodological approaches to studying consumer phenomena.

## 2. Conceptualization

Luxury is defined as "expensive and exclusive products and brands that are differentiated from other offers based on their exquisite design and craftsmanship, sensory appeal, and distinct socio-cultural narratives" (Wang, 2022, p.788). Positioned uniquely at the apex of price and status hierarchies, luxury products and brands generally serve as powerful symbols capable of signaling positive attributes about their owners.

However, the luxury industry and its brands frequently face criticism for promoting materialism, overconsumption, and extravagance (Amatulli et al., 2020). Luxury brands have also been blamed for reinforcing class distinctions (Armitage & Roberts, 2014), contributing to unsustainable production practices (Bhar et al., 2024), and perpetuating problematic labor conditions (Kapferer & Michaut-Denizeau, 2014). Similarly, luxury consumers are often criticized for their consumption patterns (Jung et al., 2024); the effectiveness and impact of shaming on an individual depend significantly on how that person perceives and internalizes these judgments (Bates & LaBrecque, 2020).

### 2.1. *Luxury signaling*

Since Veblen's seminal work (1899), luxury consumption has been associated with exclusivity and high social status; with consumers using luxury to signal wealth and prestige (Han et al., 2010; Wang & Griskevicius, 2014). However, this status-centric, wealth-related perspective does not fully capture contemporary luxury consumption. Today, luxury consumers also use high-end purchases to signal competence, knowledge of craftsmanship, refined tastes, and sensitivity to luxury symbolism (Wang, 2022). Evaluations of luxury, therefore, extend beyond financial means to judgments of taste, authenticity, and responsibility. In addition, consumers also employ alternative signals of status besides wealth, including time as a resource, aesthetics, and sustainability (Bellezza, 2023).

Importantly, luxury consumption takes place within a performative marketplace, where evaluations are visible, socially charged, and subject to constant scrutiny. These judgments can be distinctly negative and lead to sharp social criticism and disapproval of individuals who engage in luxury consumption. Given their consumer competencies (Wang, 2022), luxury consumers are likely aware of these judgments—especially when they are echoed or copied by other consumers—which in turn shape how luxury consumers perceive, feel, and react.

To date, research on luxury has primarily focused on the positive associations of luxury consumption, such as status signaling and social prestige (Eckhardt et al., 2015; Goor et al., 2021; Han et al., 2010; Yao, 2023) and enhanced self-esteem (Lee & Shrum, 2012; Truong & McColl, 2011). Negative experiences, however, have been examined in a fragmented way. For example, studies link luxury to impostor feelings when purchases feel undeserved (Goor et al., 2020; Marder et al., 2024), or luxury consumers experience guilt when consumption highlights inequality or irresponsibility (Amatulli et al., 2020; Kapferer & Valette-Florence, 2022).

Another negative emotion that has been tied to luxury is envy. Belk (2011) argues that luxury can evoke benign envy, resulting in a desire to "level up" through emulation of others' possessions, in contrast to malicious envy, which aims to deprive others of their possessions. Empirical studies demonstrate that benign envy is indeed a stronger predictor of the desire to purchase luxury fashion items than malicious envy (Loureiro et al., 2020). On social media, benign envy also prompts positive interactions and self-enhancement actions, while malicious envy leads to negative interactions with the envied (Miao et al., 2025). Finally, consumer envy, together with brand admiration, has positive effects on emotional brand attachment and brand forgiveness (Joo & Kim, 2021).

While insightful, this work tends to isolate specific emotions or individual responses (Goor et al., 2020; Kapferer & Valette-Florence, 2022; Wong et al., 2024). In contrast, our research approaches the dark side of luxury as part of a more comprehensive and systematic perspective by shifting the focus to the interpersonal and social dynamics of luxury shaming. Specifically, we position the emotion of shame itself, along with related feelings such as guilt, envy, embarrassment, anxiety, and other negative emotions, as well as perceptions of privilege, inequality, and related criticisms, as parts of the broader social phenomenon of luxury shaming.

### 2.2. *The experience of luxury shaming*

Shame has long been studied across philosophy, psychology, sociology, and management (Daniels & Robinson, 2019; Riezler, 1943; Scheff, 2000; Shaughnessy, 2018). It is a self-conscious emotion arising from a negative self-evaluation and is central to human social experience (Lewis, 1992). Shame often emerges when individuals perceive themselves as failing to meet personal or social standards. Sociologically, shame is intertwined with social bonds and reactions to perceived deviations from group norms (Scheff, 2000). Psychologically, shame is related to guilt (Tangney et al., 1996), though they are conceptually distinct. Guilt emphasizes individual responsibility, whereas shame is rooted in perceived failure to meet the expectations of others (Bedford & Hwang, 2003). This distinction also has cultural implications, with guilt more common in individualistic, Western societies and shame in more social, Eastern contexts (Bedford & Hwang, 2003). Although we do not address cross-cultural differences, these insights are valuable; they suggest that shame should be the dominant emotion at play, because shaming involves a social interaction between shamer and shamed. However, prior research also showed that guilt and shame co-occur (Tangney et al., 1996), and this is what we also find in our studies.

Shaming refers to comments and behaviors intended to elicit the feeling of shame in others (Bates & LaBrecque, 2020). Shaming can range from subtle social cues of disapproval to outright condemnation and serves as a mechanism of social control by reinforcing normative expectations within communities. A shamer's act of shaming typically leads to the experience of shame in the target, often accompanied by emotions such as anxiety, worry, or anger (Scheff, 2000). Shaming can be purposeful, such as using explicit "naming and shaming" practices, or unintentional, for example, casually expressing disapproval (Daniels and Robinson, 2019).

In luxury contexts, self-involvement takes on heightened significance because consumption is deeply tied to status, taste, and cultural legitimacy (Bourdieu, 1984), defining who is seen as an "authentic" luxury consumer and who is not (Lamont & Molnár, 2002). Luxury shaming thus reinforces cultural hierarchies and creates stigma and identity threats, which require active management, leading to emotion-focused coping strategies (Folkman & Moskowitz, 2004; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). In coping theory, stress arises when encounters are appraised as threatening or exceeding one's resources (Folkman et al., 1986; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). Stressful encounters, such as shaming, trigger both emotions and coping efforts: feelings like shame, guilt, or anxiety emerge, and coping strategies are adopted to manage both the situation and its emotional impact (Smith, 1989), with effectiveness varying across individuals and contexts (Baker & Berenbaum, 2007). Thus, luxury shaming and coping form an intertwined process: social and personal emotions elicited by the stressful shaming encounter directly shape the strategies consumers employ to protect their identity and manage threats.

### 2.3. An overview of the research

This research aims to systematically investigate the phenomenon of luxury shaming. Our research focuses on three interconnected layers of luxury shaming: (1) negative perceptions of the luxury industry, brands, and consumers within the broader marketplace; (2) the judgment content categories used by shamers as well as the cognitions and emotions of the shamed; and (3) coping mechanisms activated when luxury shaming occurs. Fig. 1 summarizes this research, with the top row highlighting key insights and the bottom row showing the progression of studies and methods that generated them. The five shaming categories—Intellectual, Economic, Socio-cultural, Physical/Aesthetic, and Ethical/Moral—are derived from GenAI analysis of marketplace discourse (Study 1) and confirmed by a qualitative consumer study (Study 2). Emotions are identified in the same qualitative study (Study 2). Finally, three bipolar coping dimensions– stylistic, social-interactive, and value-related—emerge from another qualitative study (Study 3) and are validated through simulated experimentation (Study 4).

## 3. Methodology

We chose a qualitative methodology because, in the early stages of exploring a new research topic such as luxury shaming, it provides richer insights into consumer experiences than experimental approaches (Braun & Clarke, 2014). To extend this, we adopted an innovative hybrid design that combines traditional qualitative methods with GenAI. As a large language model (LLM), GenAI provides efficient means of accessing information, analyzing qualitative data, and presenting insights (Wahid et al., 2023). GenAI supported the project in three ways: synthesizing marketplace discourse, analyzing qualitative consumer data (in parallel with human analysis), and simulating an experimental scenario. All GenAI-generated outputs were reviewed and validated by human researchers. This hybrid approach leverages the breadth and efficiency of GenAI alongside the contextual understanding, theoretical framing, and interpretive depth of human expertise, enhancing the robustness of our findings.

GenAI, such as ChatGPT (developed by OpenAI) and Gemini (developed by Google DeepMind), are LLMs that generate text responses through natural language processing (Lund et al., 2023; Paul et al., 2023). Their potential for qualitative, language-based data is increasingly recognized (Epp & Humphreys, 2025; Lund et al., 2023; Schmitt, 2024, 2025). Recently, guidelines have been proposed for using GenAI for cultural analysis (Epp and Humphreys, 2025), which we follow in our research.

In Study 1, we tasked ChatGPT to collate negative perceptions related to luxury consumption, brands, and the industry, alongside pertinent industry examples. In Studies 2 and 3, NotebookLM (a Gemini-powered tool) was used alongside human coding to analyze interview transcripts, identify recurring themes, and extract insights into how consumers shame others and respond emotionally and cope when being shamed. Finally, in Study 4, leveraging the potential of LLMs in simulating and predicting real-life responses (Mou et al., 2024; Park et al., 2024), we used NotebookLM and ChatGPT to create 1000 distinct synthetic personae based on the real consumer interviews in Studies 2 and 3 to simulate luxury consumers' responses when shamed.

To address limitations such as hallucinations or irrelevant content (Lund et al., 2023; Methnani et al., 2023; Omar et al., 2025), we implemented a structured validation process across all studies. We independently reviewed AI-generated output for accuracy, relevance, and research objective alignment. Human-coded data were also checked for factual accuracy, conceptual fit, and completeness, with disagreements resolved through discussion. For Study 4, the review further included evaluating the simulated personae responses, ensuring that they reflected realistic personae consistent with the qualitative findings from earlier studies.

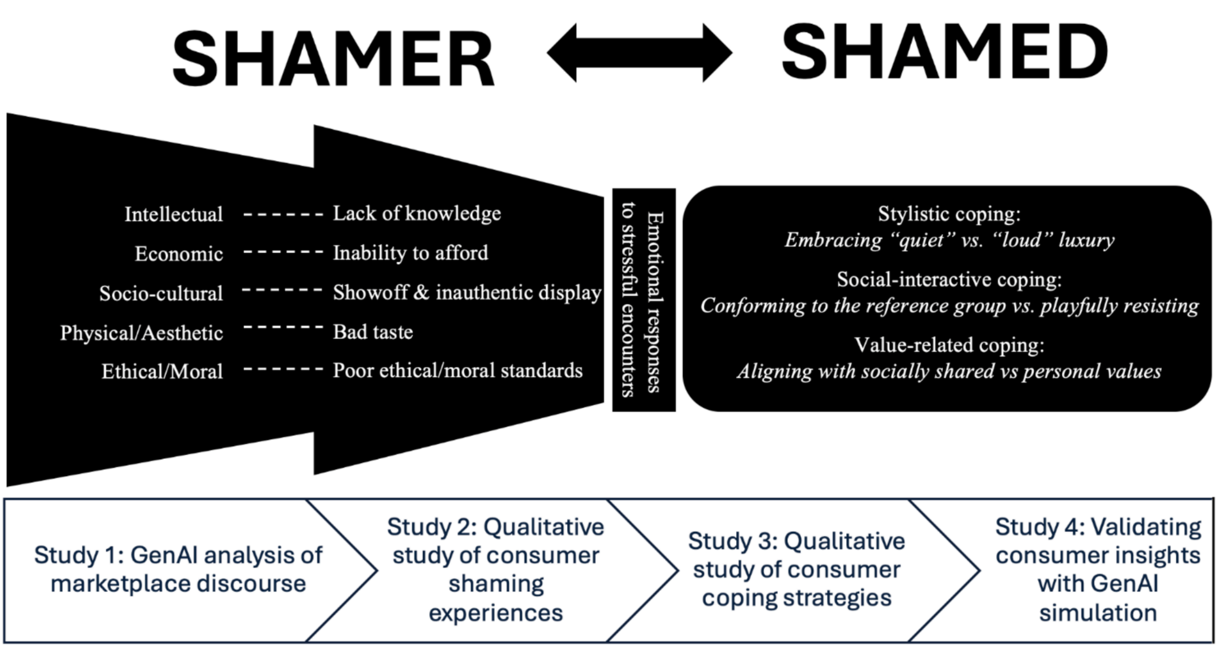


**Fig. 1.** Main insights emerging from the progression of studies.

## 4. Study 1: GenAI analysis of shaming discourse in the marketplace

### 4.1. Method

To provide a structured understanding of the negative perceptions present in the marketplace, we used ChatGPT to identify key shaming arguments and present them along several shaming categories. As an LLM, ChatGPT can efficiently identify and analyze large amounts of textual data (Wachinger et al., 2024). Operationally, we developed and applied separate prompt sets for each of the three levels of analysis—luxury consumption, luxury brands, and luxury industry—to ensure that distinct perspectives were captured. At each level, prompts were designed to retrieve three types of content: (1) brand or product examples discussed in online sources with verifiable links, (2) real-world brand and product cases discussed in credible sources, and (3) quotations from major thinkers, writers, sociologists, and philosophers related to each association.

To improve the quality and precision of results, we gradually refined the prompts over multiple rounds. In each round, we reviewed the output, identified issues such as vagueness or irrelevant sourcing, and then adjusted the prompts, for example, by specifying the type of sources, the tone of responses, or the framing of shaming arguments. While the wording of prompts evolved, the underlying logic and structure remained consistent, allowing for replication of the overall approach.

To identify marketplace evidence, ChatGPT was explicitly instructed to draw from “reputable, widely circulated sources,” including international and regional newspapers (e.g., The New York Times, The Guardian, South China Morning Post), industry publications (e.g., The Business of Fashion, Luxury Daily, Jing Daily), well-established books from academic and trade presses (e.g., Oxford University Press, Harvard Business Review Press). Selection emphasized diversity of geographical coverage, relevance to luxury markets, and recency where applicable. All AI-generated outputs were systematically reviewed for accuracy, credibility, and alignment with the topic. Approximately 30 % of responses were excluded due to unverifiable claims, low-quality sourcing, and topic misfit.

Next, using expert judgment, we refined the specific shaming dimensions into five categories: Intellectual, Economic, Socio-cultural, Physical/Aesthetic, and Ethical/Moral. To ensure comprehensive coverage, we then used an iterative procedure, asking ChatGPT to identify potential missing elements. Finally, we substantiated the identified content with real-world marketplace evidence by prompting ChatGPT to locate examples from credible media sources.

### 4.2. Results

In response to a general prompt requesting “a comprehensive list of negative associations/perceptions,” separately for luxury consumption, luxury brands, and the luxury industry, ChatGPT generated the following for luxury consumption: *Excessive Materialism*, *Snobbery or Elitism*, *Environmental Impact*, *Economic Inequality*, *Shallow Values*, *Lack of Authenticity*, *Social Alienation*, *Overcompensation*, *Frivolity*, *Cultural Insensitivity*, *Encouragement of Debt*, *Hyper-Individualism*, *Lack of Emotional Fulfillment*, *Over-Indulgence,* and *Perpetuation of Stereotypes*. ChatGPT also generated the following negative associations for luxury brands: *Exclusivity and Inaccessibility*, *Unethical Practices*, *Price Gouging*, *Artificial Scarcity*, *Superficial Branding*, *Overemphasis on Status*, *Cultural Insensitivity*, *Elitist Marketing*, *Counterfeit Problems*, *Over-commercialization*, *Exploitation of Aspirational Consumers*, *Disconnection from Societal Needs*, *Limited Innovation*, *Perceived Pretentiousness*, and *Trend-Chasing*. Finally, ChatGPT created the following negative associations for the luxury industry: *Environmental Degradation*, *Labor Exploitation*, *Perpetuation of Inequality*, *Tax Avoidance*, *Greenwashing*, *Cultural Appropriation*, *Lack of Transparency*, *Focus on Profit Over Values*, *Encouragement of Overconsumption*, *Artificial Inflation of Value*, *Over-Production*, *Gentrification*, *Social Division*, *Corporate Arrogance*, and *Lack of Accessibility*.

Note that the three domains (consumption, brands, and industry) share overlapping content dimensions. Together with GenAI, we consolidated these overlaps into 28 dimensions and grouped them into five categories—Intellectual, Economic, Socio-cultural, Physical/Aesthetic, and Ethical/Moral (see Table 1). To support the marketplace realism of the dimensions within each category, we instructed ChatGPT to provide articles from global newspapers such as The Wall Street Journal, The Business Financial Times, and The Guardian Australia; industry-specific publications such as Luxury Tribune, Cranbourne, and Vogue Business; and academic sources such as INSEAD Knowledge, Rutgers University, as well as books (e.g., Cambridge University Press).

The identified content categories demonstrate face validity, as they reflect widespread critiques central to luxury consumption, brands, and the industry. These categories thus represent the broader negative discourse surrounding luxury in the marketplace.

Building on the findings of Study 1, Studies 2 and 3 employ qualitative interviews. We interviewed a total of 28 luxury consumers from Europe, the Middle East, and China, regions that represent major luxury markets. In Study 2, we examine how consumers refer to and enact the negative perceptions from the marketplace, i.e., how they engage in intellectual, economic, socio-cultural, physical/aesthetic, and ethical/moral shaming of other consumers; we also explore how shamed consumers feel. In Study 3, we study how luxury consumers cope with luxury shaming in their everyday lives.

## 5. Study 2: Exploring consumer shaming and emotional responses

### 5.1. Method

We conducted 14 semi-structured interviews to explore luxury shaming from the consumer’s perspective. The interviews opened with broad questions about participants’ own luxury consumption practices, including what they enjoyed, what they disliked, and how these purchases made them feel. This helped establish rapport and allowed

**Table 1**
Final shaming content dimensions across five general categories.

| Shaming category | Specific shaming content dimensions |
| --- | --- |
| **Intellectual Shaming** | – Superficial Values and Distorted Priorities<br>– Cultural Insensitivity and Homogenization<br>– Limited Innovation and Planned Obsolescence<br>– Greenwashing and Inauthentic Marketing<br>– Loss of Authenticity |
| **Economic Shaming** | – Economic Inequality and Conspicuous Waste<br>– Debt, Financial Instability, and Encouragement of Debt<br>– Price Gouging, Inflation, Market Manipulation, and Artificial Scarcity<br>– Tax Avoidance and Economic Manipulation |
| **Socio-Cultural Shaming** | – Elitism, Snobbery, and Social Division<br>– Social Comparison, Isolation, and Status Anxiety<br>– Exploitation of Aspirations and Perpetuation of Stereotypes<br>– Impact on Traditional Practices<br>– Cultural Commodification, Gentrification, and Impact on Local Economies |
| **Physical/Aesthetic Shaming** | – Frivolity and Superficial Branding<br>– Overemphasis on Status, Logo Mania, and Brand Dilution<br>– Negative Brand Associations and Trend-Chasing<br>– Design Exclusivity |
| **Ethical/Moral Shaming** | – Environmental Impact and Unethical Practices<br>– Corporate Arrogance, Encouragement of Overconsumption, and Promotion of Consumerism<br>– Focus on Profit Over Values, Social Responsibility Failures, and Labor Exploitation<br>– Moral Conflicts and Animal Cruelty<br>– Transparency and Accountability Issues |

participants to reflect on their motivations and potential tensions. The conversation then moved to negative experiences, focusing on participants either criticizing others, observing disapproving reactions, or receiving negative judgments themselves. We avoided the explicit term “luxury shaming” because using it could bias responses and limit disclosure. This approach encouraged participants to articulate their own feelings and behaviors more openly (Potter & Hepburn, 2020). Ambiguities were clarified when needed (Bryman, 2012).

Respondents were recruited via snowball and purposive sampling (Etikan et al., 2016). Initial participants were approached through the researchers’ professional and social networks, and subsequent participants were identified through referrals. All participants were verified as luxury consumers following the procedure of Kapferer and Laurent (2016). The sample included 8 women and 6 men, aged 22–42, from diverse educational, professional, and regional backgrounds (Europe, the Middle East, and China). Full demographic details are shown in Table 2 (upper section). The sample size meets established guidelines for qualitative inquiry (McCracken, 1988; Guest et al., 2006), and interviews continued until thematic saturation and data variability were reached (Boddy, 2016; Guest et al., 2006). The interviews were conducted in English (for participants from Europe and the Middle East) or in Chinese, either online or in person; they lasted an average of 42 min.

First, we conducted a standard manual thematic analysis of interview data using Nvivo software (Miles et al., 2014). A research team of multiple coders read through all transcripts independently, coding references to luxury shaming and negative perceptions. Through regular discussions, disagreements in coding were resolved, and initial themes were developed. Subsequently, we applied axial coding (Strauss & Corbin, 1990): we organized themes into broader conceptual categories to establish meaningful relationships among them. This manual process ensured interpretive and contextual understanding, which the automated analysis might overlook or misinterpret.

In parallel with human manual analysis, we employed a GenAI-assisted approach using NotebookLM, chosen for its strong privacy assurances. Its summarization capabilities supported and validated human thematic analysis by highlighting key themes, patterns, and variations in participants’ perceptions of shaming and emotional responses. As with the manual coding, axial coding (Strauss & Corbin, 1998) was then applied to refine these themes in line with theoretical constructs and lived experiences. Since AI lacks autonomous agency, embodied experience, and historical context, which may lead to superfacial insights and limit theoretical innovation (Epp & Humphreys, 2025), human judgment was employed for validating AI-generated insights and ensuring rigor and contextual relevance (Lund et al., 2023). We systematically reviewed, refined, and reinterpreted GenAI outputs to ensure rigor and contextual relevance before consolidating both analyses into a unified framework.

**Table 2**
Respondent profiles.

| | Name | Gender | Age | Profession |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Study 2** | Paul | Male | 41 | Manager |
| | Catherene | Female | 27 | Academic project coordinator |
| | Maria | Female | 40 | Solutions director tech company |
| | Gao | Female | 42 | Business development director |
| | Lora | Female | 35 | Luxury sales |
| | Luzian | Male | 37 | International business manager |
| | Pauline | Female | 42 | Academic |
| | Serena | Female | 37 | Pianist |
| | Yu | Male | 43 | Manager |
| | Zack | Male | 25 | Student |
| | Hatty | Male | 27 | Financial analyst |
| | Haya | Male | 37 | Director of communication |
| | Yara | Female | 26 | Marketing |
| | Queeny | Female | 22 | Digital marketing specialist |
| **Study 3** | Vanni | Female | 36 | Sales manager |
| | David | Male | 27 | Analyst |
| | Haotian | Male | 27 | Master student |
| | Jim | Female | 29 | Student |
| | Kai | Male | 27 | Student |
| | Kevin | Male | 40 | Exporter |
| | Max | Male | 30 | Business development director |
| | Nina | Female | 56 | Manager |
| | Rosalia | Female | 27 | PR coordinator |
| | Wendy | Female | 45 | Real estate |
| | Yuan | Male | 27 | Analyst |
| | Ziwei | Male | 34 | Professional buyer |
| | Yokim | Male | 26 | Student |
| | Diana | Female | 29 | Graphic designer |

### 5.2. Results

Our findings show the dual nature of luxury shaming: individuals often find themselves both in the role of shamer and the role of the shamed. Most importantly, results indicated that shaming seems to be perceptually triggered, behaviorally enacted, and verbally expressed within the five categories discussed in Study 1, resulting in Intellectual, Economic, Socio-Cultural, Physical/Aesthetic, and Ethical/Moral Shaming. In the following, we provide details and examples from the thematic analysis in each category, primarily from the shamer’s perspective. Pseudonyms will be used in place of participants’ real names to ensure confidentiality.

#### 5.2.1. Intellectual shaming

Shaming in the intellectual domain arises from the perception and belief that some consumers lack true knowledge in luxury consumption. As a result, consumers who shame others believe that the shamed consumers engage with luxury only superficially rather than authentically. Yara highlights, “They know brands like Gucci, Louis Vuitton, and Dior, but they wouldn’t recognize a brand like Bottega Veneta,” suggesting that familiarity with only mainstream brands signals a lack of deeper understanding. Lora reinforces this idea, “He only wants Loro Piana because it’s the most popular brand right now, and he wants their most popular item: the shoes. That’s all he knows.” Similarly, Luzian critiques performative consumption, stating, “I see people who travel to Paris or Milan, and they just buy to show that they’re shopping there; it’s a performance […] They don’t even know how to wear these items.” These perspectives illustrate how intellectual luxury shaming is mostly linked to perceived superficiality, whereas true engagement is seen as requiring not just financial access but also knowledge and cultural capital.

#### 5.2.2. Economic shaming

Shaming in the economic realm centers around affordability and the source of wealth. Consumers shame others by questioning whether they can truly afford luxury goods. Conversely, the shamed luxury consumers report negative feelings when others question whether they can afford a luxury good and wonder why they may actually have it.

For example, Gao commented, “They could use this amount of money to do something else that they really need, for example, to pay rent, to pay the bills every day in their house.” Yu stated, “Especially for some girls, they may save a large part of their money to buy a bag, or even take a loan to buy a bag […] Actually, my assistant’s salary is not high. But she has many branded bags, such as Chanel and Dior, and each bag costs thousands […] They will save money to buy this bag in the end […] I don't understand [this].” Kai highlights the perception that some individuals stretch their finances to attain luxury: “I think there will still be some people who will save money to buy things in installments, just pursuing luxury.” Serena’s remarks further illustrate how economic shaming is often gendered, specifically associating women’s public displays of luxury with financial dependence on men, stating, “These ‘sugar babies’ need attention. They post photos of luxury on public accounts, and it's evident they are being sponsored by a sugar daddy.”.

#### 5.2.3. Socio-cultural shaming

Socio-cultural shaming arises from perceptions of inauthentic status signaling. Consumers seem to assume that only some consumers are legitimized to buy luxury, for example, a certain social class or "old money." For example, Gao noted, "They're not at this level to be in a group of people, but they want to be in it… by using a Chanel bag, they will appear to be on the same level." Paul criticized overt attempts to flaunt wealth, stating, "They just wanna show off and show who is more successful. They started to show where they spend their holidays, and they showed photos……. it's a very silly discussion." Similarly, Zack noted, "I feel like they might be trying to gain attention […] and for vanity.".

#### 5.2.4. Physical/aesthetic shaming

Physical/aesthetic shaming revolves around judgments of personal style. For example, consumers are judged to lack style and taste or to be only externally oriented. Hatty observed, "She does not show her true self, only the one she wants the world to see." Pauline's experience illustrates this dynamic: "I got [negative] comments on my [Burberry] trench as well." Catherine takes this further, equating luxury with old money aesthetics by saying, "Luxury is only old money aesthetics; all the rest is like you're trying so hard." She dismisses those who do not embody this ideal as "try-hards" attempting to emulate a status they do not truly possess. This rigid boundary frames certain forms of luxury expressions as indicators of insecurity.

#### 5.2.5. Ethical/moral shaming

Finally, shaming can also relate to ethical and moral considerations. Serena critiques overconsumption, suggesting it contradicts sustainability. Maria and Paul express skepticism about sustainability claims in luxury. Maria notes, "You would find a similar item [but without a sustainability claim] with the same quality at a lower price," while Paul dismisses such claims entirely: "I don't care about sustainability, it's just marketing, they are lying.".

#### 5.2.6. The dual role of luxury consumers: When the shamer becomes the shamed

While the preceding analysis highlighted how consumers shame others for their luxury consumption, our findings also reveal that many recount being shamed themselves—in fact, along the very same dimensions.. For instance, in the intellectual category, Pauline was judged for her lack of understanding of real luxury. In the economic category, Gao faces criticism from her mother, who condemns her spending as wasteful; she also views Gao's luxury purchases through socio-cultural lenses by invoking the Chinese concept of "Fu Bao" (fortune and luck), believing such extravagance will damage Gao's fortune and luck. Luzian recounted being teased aesthetically for wearing prominent logos, while others recalled remarks that portrayed their consumption as environmentally irresponsible.

The experiences reported by participants in their role of the shamed often carried strong emotional consequences because many critical remarks came from family members or peers in their close social circles. Some participants also mentioned colleagues or acquaintances, as well as strangers in more public contexts such as social media, online forums, or comment threads, where judgments were less personally connected. Across these contexts, participants described both social and personal emotions. Social emotions included the core emotion of shame as well as embarrassment and anxiety when their purchases attracted public criticism; for example, Pauline worried that "maybe people might comment," revealing her sensitivity to social scrutiny. Personal emotions included feelings of inferiority, guilt, and self-doubt. Luzian, for instance, reflected that buying secondhand could be read as "having less money" and thus lower status, while Gao described luxury consumption as "an unhappy experience" under judgment. For some, shaming created ongoing discomfort and eroded confidence, as Haya admitted, "Sometimes, I have doubts if I look good […] so I trust my mom and husband.".

### 5.3. Discussion

The results of Study 2 reveal the increasingly scrutinized nature of luxury consumption, where individuals face critiques along multiple categories: consumers may be shamed intellectually (e.g., perceived as lacking genuine understanding), economically (e.g., judged for irresponsible spending or showing off wealth), socio-culturally (e.g., viewed as inauthentically attempting to elevate their social status), physically/aesthetically (e.g., criticized for inappropriate or exaggerated displays of luxury items), and ethically/morally (e.g., questioned for supporting brands that are perceived as unsustainable or ethically problematic).

The emotional impact of luxury shaming is equally complex, with participants experiencing a variety of social and personal emotions, including shame itself as well as embarrassment, guilt, and anxiety. Importantly, our findings revealed a duality of roles: consumers not only shamed but also were shamed. In Study 3, we further explored the perspective of the shamed consumers, specifically by investigating coping strategies that enable consumers to maintain their engagement with luxury.

## 6. Study 3: Understanding consumer coping strategies

### 6.1. Method

We conducted 14 (male = 8; female = 6) additional semi-structured interviews using a new sample of participants. As in Study 2, we used purposive sampling (Etikan et al., 2016); the sample included again respondents across various age groups (26 to 56), educational and professional backgrounds, and geographical regions. The interviews, which lasted between 20 and 71 min, were audio-recorded, with consent, and transcribed verbatim for analysis. The questions were asked in a similar manner as study 2, focusing on the experience of being shamed and, specifically, how to cope with it. Sample questions included: "Have you received any negative comments on your luxury purchase? How did you feel and how did you respond?" "When someone comments negatively on your luxury consumption, what do you usually do in the moment or after? Do you continue using the item in the same way, or do you change the way you use it?" In addition, participants were encouraged to share specific incidents where others' reactions had made them uncomfortable or led them to reconsider their consumption choices. Table 2 (lower section) shows the respondents' profiles. We followed the same approach as Study 2 for data analysis: we conducted a thematic analysis using NVivo (Miles et al., 2014), alongside NotebookLM, to identify coping mechanisms. AI-generated themes were iteratively reviewed and refined by researchers to ensure theoretical and contextual alignment.

### 6.2. Results

Our analysis reveals that luxury consumers employ various coping strategies to mitigate the stress and emotional impact of shaming, protect their self-concept, and maintain engagement with luxury consumption. In line with coping theory (Folkman et al., 1986; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984), these strategies can be understood as adaptive responses to stressful encounters, aimed at managing both the external stressor of social judgment and its internal emotional consequences (e.g., shame, guilt, or anxiety). Coping thus helps individuals regulate negative emotions resulting from social critique while preserving status, self-esteem, and a sense of identity. These responses appear along three bipolar dimensions, each comprising two contrasting forms of coping: Stylistic Coping (embracing "quiet" luxury vs. "loud" luxury); Social-Interactive Coping (conforming to the luxury reference group vs. playfully resisting it), and Value-Related Coping (aligning with socially shared values vs. personal values).

#### 6.2.1. Stylistic Coping: Embracing "quiet" vs. "loud" luxury

A prevalent coping strategy is opting for quiet luxury, wherein consumers deliberately opt for understated luxury items that lack prominent branding to avoid attracting negative attention. Here, stressful encounters are managed through minimization: by reducing visibility, consumers reduce the likelihood of triggering further social judgment, thereby lowering anticipatory stress. Wendy gives an example: "It must be the kind of niche product with particularly good quality. For example, (…) I especially like to go to Italy and Spain to buy those niche products." Her emphasis on craftsmanship and exclusivity, rooted in personal appreciation rather than mass recognition, reflects how quiet luxury functions as a stress-buffering mechanism, allowing consumers to maintain engagement with luxury goods while sidestepping social scrutiny.

The stylistic choice of quietness may also include a preference for natural styles. It enables consumers to resist accusations of inauthenticity by framing their choices as driven by understated elegance. Consumers who prefer subtlety over overt branding view understated styles as more sophisticated. Haotian describes his purchasing decisions as primarily influenced by personal aesthetic preferences, explaining, "When I buy things, it mainly depends on my own preferences. I don't really like to buy that kind of exaggerated look, such as a big logo printed on the body; maybe a little low-key, and this style is more beautiful." Likewise, Ziwei underlines the appeal of simplicity, stating, "I just like simplicity, but with a little bit of uniqueness." By favoring natural aesthetics and minimalist luxury, these consumers strategically counteract the shaming associated with overt displays of wealth.

In contrast, to cope with luxury shaming, consumers may embrace excess as a form of defiance. Rather than reducing exposure to stressful encounters, they transform stress by leaning into ostentatious display as a means of regaining control. Yoki describes wearing "women's high-heeled boots… very exaggerated," signaling a conscious push against conventional expectations. Similarly, Yuan recounts dressing in pants adorned with "seven or eight bags." As Yuan reflects, "I will still use this as a topic for curiosity or to communicate." Such flamboyant fashion is a way of doubling down on conspicuous luxury to assert the right to luxury, thus reconfiguring disapproval into cultural capital.

#### 6.2.2. Social-interactive coping: conforming to the reference group vs. playfully resisting it

Another common conforming coping strategy is shopping with companions with similar interests and purchasing power to avoid discomfort or judgment. Here, stress is managed through proactive context control: by shaping the social environment, consumers reduce the likelihood of stressful confrontations. As Haotian explains, "I might take people who have the same purchasing power as me to go shopping together […] like my neighbor, I have a good relationship with him." This selective association helps consumers avoid potential criticism by controlling how and with whom their luxury is displayed, thus countering socio-cultural shaming by aligning consumption with social norms.

Similarly, as a coping strategy, consumers may manage their appearance and social context to avoid judgment and preserve their group connection. Wendy offers a clear example of an assimilation approach in a group setting. In her case, it is about distancing from the lower-ranked colleagues and assimilating with high-net-worth-individuals: "Look at my subordinates, they all carry LV bags. Me, I only wear black or gold skirts, and the jewelry with gold that has no logo… let my clients think about it, are they all worth hundreds of millions?" She distances herself from flashier peers and creates a curated social environment where her luxury is recognized by others without being scrutinized, illustrating how luxury consumers may retreat into selective expression to protect their self-concept and professional positioning.

In contrast, playful resistance emerges as a coping strategy in which consumers respond to luxury shaming with humor, irony, or nonchalant confidence, deflecting critique while reaffirming their personal worth and style. Rather than internalizing judgment or engaging in confrontation, they use lightness and wit to disarm criticism. Max illustrates this strategy when a girl mocked his Dior suit, implying it looks cheap: "She said, 'From where did you get your suit? From Carrefour?' I just laughed. I said, 'Whatever I wear, if I wear from Carrefour or Splash [fast fashion brand], I would be handsome." By invoking humor and asserting that his appearance transcends the price of his clothing, Max resists the pressure to justify or defend his choices. This playful deflection protects one's self-esteem and subtly rebuts the negative judgments on luxury consumption.

#### 6.2.3. Value-related coping: aligning with socially shared vs. personal values

Given that luxury goods are assumed to be well-crafted, a socially shared value of any luxury purchase is quality and durability. Thus, another coping strategy is to frame luxury purchases as investments, and related values such as functionality and practicality, rather than as mere status symbols. Here, stress is regulated through cognitive reappraisal: criticism is reinterpreted as misunderstanding, while the consumer repositions their choice as rational or morally aligned, thereby countering criticisms of materialism as well as economic and financial irresponsibility. Diana notes, "It's not like ridiculously expensive, but it's very good quality." Similarly, Yuan explains that he considers whether luxury items "can be maintained to some extent in the secondary market." These views reposition luxury as practical rather than indulgent. By emphasizing longevity and future worth, these consumers mitigate the perception of luxury as frivolous spending, reinforcing its role as a rational and economically sound choice.

Others align luxury with broader social values, such as ethics or sustainability. This allows individuals to justify their consumption by aligning it with responsible and value-driven decision-making. Kai provides an example: "When I browse Tiffany's official website, I look at what they do for environmental protection. […] I bought a Tiffany necklace for my ex-girlfriend. Well, they donated the money to the Wildlife Conservation Network for every necklace they sold." However, some consumers respond to ethical criticisms by expressing skepticism toward corporate sustainability claims, thus reframing the discourse around ethical consumption.

In contrast, some consumers engage in value-related coping by assuring their own personal values and dismissing others' opinions. Rather than feeling the need to justify or change, they exhibit a strong internal locus of validation, dismissing external judgments that are not aligned with their own personal values. As Vanni asserts, "No matter what they say about me, it means nothing to me," clearly expressing a refusal to internalize criticism. Similarly, Jim downplays potential judgment by stating, "I'm not very concerned about [those] aspects, unless he says it to me in front of me," reinforcing the idea that only direct confrontation might register, and even then, with limited emotional impact. This coping strategy reflects a psychologically resilient approach, allowing consumers to preserve their sense of identity without being swayed by social scrutiny, thus enabling continued engagement with luxury goods.

### 6.3. Discussion

Study 3 focuses on the psychological and behavioral coping strategies of luxury consumers in response to shaming. Our analysis reveals that consumers actively engage in coping strategies to protect their self-concept and justify their purchases. Rather than disengaging from luxury consumption, individuals develop diverse mechanisms to navigate social scrutiny to remain engaged as luxury consumers. Extending existing psychology research on coping (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984), our study shows how consumers strategically manage their luxury consumption under conditions of a stressful emotional judgment.

## 7. Study 4: Validating consumer insights with GenAI simulation

To validate our insights and demonstrate that they may be consequential and relevant, we employed a GenAI simulation. Following prior pioneering approaches (Mou et al., 2024; Park et al., 2024), which used GenAI to construct personae (digital twins) based on data from qualitative interviews, we created personae based on our own qualitative data. We then scaled these personae for a simulation that included an experimental shaming manipulation relative to a control group. After randomly assigning personae to one of the two groups, we simulated their responses to 27 statements modeled on the coping responses identified in Study 3 (see the following section for a description of the statement development process). We expected the simulation experimental group (the "shamed") would show higher engagement in coping responses than the control group (not shamed) because coping is only necessary if a consumer encounters the stressful situation of shaming. Such differences would indicate that the coping strategies identified in the qualitative studies reflect meaningful, consequential consumer responses rather than hypothetical ones. In addition to the core experimental simulation part of the study, we investigated whether we could replicate the three-dimensional bipolar conceptual structure of coping strategies observed earlier.

### 7.1. Data collection & analysis

We used NotebookLM to create consumer personae derived from the interview data from Studies 2 and 3. To scale them beyond the small qualitative samples, building upon existing research (Mou et al., 2024; Park et al., 2024), we generated a total of 1,000 unique consumer personae using GenAI. We first used NotebookLM to generate detailed summaries of each interview respondent, capturing demographic, behavioral, and psychological characteristics relevant to luxury consumption. Using these respondent-based summaries as the foundation, we next employed ChatGPT to scale these profiles to 100 distinct personae. The prompt instructed the model to preserve the core characteristics of each original respondent while introducing variation across demographic, behavioral, and psychological dimensions. Meanwhile, we conducted a manual review and removed cases that appeared overly similar or insufficiently plausible. This process was repeated ten times, yielding 1,000 unique personae. Grounding the scenario in persona-specific characteristics helped reduce the tendency of large language models to default toward generic or socially normative recall descriptions.

Throughout the process, we used ChatGPT and manual review to ensure the diversity and representativeness of the personae. This hybrid human–GenAI workflow is consistent with recent approaches that suggest leveraging democratization and scale while remaining anchored in rich, human-generated inputs (Huang & Rust, 2025). The final set of personae was then randomly assigned to either the shaming (experimental) condition or the control condition ($n = 500$ per group).

In the shaming condition, the personae were prompted to recall a scenario where their luxury purchase was criticized or faced social disapproval. This recall-based approach was chosen because drawing on personally relevant contexts increases realism and ecological validity. In the control condition, no such manipulation was introduced; the personae were merely prompted to recall a luxury purchase.

As key dependent measures, we developed 27 statements grounded in the coping patterns observed in Studies 2 and 3. First, we conducted a thematic analysis of the interview data to identify distinct coping strategies used by participants in response to luxury shaming. Second, for each strategy, ChatGPT was instructed to generate three to five item candidates with explicit constraints provided (e.g., avoid overly abstract language, ensure behavioral specificity) to ensure rigor and minimize the risk of producing generic phrasing. Third, these statements were refined through multiple rounds of internal review. During this process, the research team verified not only conceptual alignment but also checked for unintended GenAI artifacts, such as repetitive syntactic structures or overly neutralized emotional language, which are known tendencies of LLMs.

During the simulation, each persona rated its agreement with the 27 statements on a 9-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree; 9 = Strongly Agree). To ensure that responses remained tied to each persona's attributes and experimental condition, the prompt instructed the model to "simulate responses from the perspective of each consumer profile," using the persona's demographic, psychological, and behavioral characteristics as well as its assigned condition. This structured prompting approach was implemented to counteract the known tendency of LLMs to default toward average or socially normative responses.

### 7.2. Results

We first assessed whether the experimental group would differ from the control group on the dependent variables to see if the shamed luxury personae showed higher engagement with coping responses than the non-shamed luxury personae. This might indicate that participants in the qualitative studies provided consequential and relevant insights. We conducted independent samples t-tests comparing personae in the shaming condition ($n = 500$) and the control condition ($n = 500$) across the 27 dependent variables. In 24 out of 27 comparisons personae exposed to the shaming condition provided higher scores than those in the control group ($p < 0.001$ for all significant differences), indicating that personae assigned to the shaming condition indeed engaged in more copying behavior than those in the control condition.

To explore the structure of these responses, we conducted an exploratory factor analysis within the shaming group. Using varimax rotation, we extracted three factors. Table 3 shows the 19 items that had substantial loadings on the three factors, which were all bipolar factors. Examining the loadings for interpreting the factors, the factors closely matched and thus could be interpreted as the three bipolar dimensions of the qualitative analysis in Study 3. The GenAI simulation thus reproduced and validated the conceptual structure of the qualitative data, illustrating how GenAI-based methods can scale qualitative insights while preserving theoretically grounded structures.

### 7.3. Discussion

Study 4 validated the insights identified in Study 3 and extended them by showing that the qualitative findings of Study 3 are likely consequential, reflecting market-relevant behavior. In addition, the three bipolar coping dimensions—stylistic, social-interactive, and value-related—were validated in the simulated responses, suggesting that these strategies are not limited to interview accounts but can be generalized across a broader set of consumer profiles.

Note, however, that the results of Study 4 should not be interpreted in the same way as findings from a traditional experiment. First, regarding sampling, the personae used were derived from a small, qualitative sample and not randomly recruited; they may thus be less representative of a broader population than experiments that typically recruit randomly from a broader set of people. Furthermore, no validity checks could be conducted against prior luxury shaming experiments, as no such precedent currently exists. The findings should therefore be viewed as a conceptual validation of the coping mechanisms and their conceptual structure identified in the qualitative Study 3. As such, Study 4 serves to enrich the qualitative investigation into luxury shaming, offering complementary insights rather than definitive causal conclusions.

Nonetheless, the GenAI-based simulation demonstrates a way to bridge qualitative insight with scalable, controlled testing. This offers researchers a tool to examine whether patterns found in smaller-sample studies persist under scaled conditions. For practitioners, the findings offer directions for exploring consumer coping strategies beyond studies with consumer samples and incorporating this understanding into brand

**Table 3**
Factor loading of the items.

| | "Quiet" Vs. "Loud" Luxury | Conforming Vs. Playfully Resisting | Socially Shared Vs. Personal Values |
|---|---|---|---|
| I will prefer the luxury style that feels natural and comfortable rather than overly styled. | *** (+) | | |
| When making luxury purchases in the future, how authentic the item makes me look will be more important to me than following luxury trends. | *** (+) | | |
| For me, true luxury should be about understated elegance rather than obvious displays of wealth. | *** (+) | | |
| I will prefer luxury items with subtle branding rather than flashy logos in my future purchases. | ** (+) | | |
| For my future purchases, I will seek out timeless, sophisticated designs over trend-driven luxury products. | * (+) | | |
| I enjoy proving people wrong by demonstrating that I can afford and sustain a luxury lifestyle. | * (−) | | |
| If someone suggests my luxury items are excessive, I will be more likely to invest in even more premium brands. | * (−) | | |
| I will prefer socializing with people who share my appreciation for luxury brands and experiences. | | ** (+) | |
| I will prefer to shop for luxury items with a specific group of people who share my shopping habits. | | ** (+) | |
| I will coordinate my luxury shopping experiences with specific individuals who understand my tastes and choices. | | ** (+) | |
| I do not feel the need to explain or defend my luxury purchases to others. | | * (−) | |
| I will not let negative comments about my luxury items influence my purchasing behavior. | | * (−) | |
| I will consider the ethical and environmental impact of a luxury brand before making a purchase in the future. | | | *** (+) |
| In the future, I will prefer to buy from luxury brands that prioritize sustainability and fair labor practices. | | | *** (+) |
| Luxury consumption should move toward greater responsibility and sustainability rather than being purely about indulgence. | | | ** (+) |
| I will rather invest in a high-quality product that lasts than a trendy luxury item for my future luxury purchase. | | | ** (+) |
| I will not let negative comments about my luxury items influence my purchasing behavior. | | | * (−) |
| People's opinions about my spending habits will have no impact on my decisions. | | | * (−) |
| When people criticize my luxury purchases, I will respond with humor. | | | * (−) |

***: High factor loading, **: Moderate factor loading, *: Marginal factor loading. (+): Positive factor loading (−): Negative factor loading.
In both the experimental shaming and control group, GenAI personae respond to the overall question what they will do and responded on the items listed.

communications, product positioning, and marketing engagement initiatives.

## 8. General discussion

This research advances the understanding of luxury shaming by offering a multi-method investigation into its psychological, social, and behavioral dynamics. Across four studies, we show that luxury consumption is increasingly scrutinized and that consumers are pulled into the social discourse occurring in the marketplace. Luxury shaming is revealed not as a one-sided effect but as a relational and performative process: consumers occupy the roles of both shamers and shamed. As shamers, they shame others using various shaming categories; as those who are shamed, they experience emotional distress and respond using diverse coping strategies.

Our results highlight the complex nature of luxury shaming, where social critiques emerge from perceptions of inauthenticity, financial irresponsibility, elitism, aesthetic misjudgment, and ethical lapses. Consumers experience both social and personal emotions—such as shame itself as well as embarrassment, guilt, and anxiety, showing how shaming functions as both a social and psychological stressor. In response, individuals adopt different coping strategies that allow them to maintain engagement with luxury consumption while managing potential identity harm. These strategies occur along three bipolar dimensions: stylistic coping (embracing either "quiet" or "loud" luxury), social-interactive coping (displaying group conformity or playful resistance), and value-related coping (grounded in either socially shared or personal values).

By incorporating GenAI into every part of the project, our work also contributes to emerging discussions on how AI can be used in marketing and consumer research (Huang and Rust 2022; Schmitt 2025). At the same time, we were cautious and conservative in the use of GenAI, extending human insight rather than replacing it, and being mindful of biases and risks of GenAI (Huang & Rust, 2025).

### 8.1. Theoretical and methodological contributions

First, our study contributes to the luxury consumption literature by studying an important, previously neglected phenomenon: luxury shaming. This work extends the understanding of positive status signaling (Eckhardt et al., 2015; Goor et al., 2021; Han et al., 2010; Yao, 2023) by revealing the social vulnerabilities and tensions that accompany attempts to establish status through luxury purchases. While luxury consumption can serve as a psychological buffer against self-threats (Sivanathan & Pettit, 2010), it can also introduce new threats—most notably, the threat of being criticized by others. Prior research has explored elements of this dark side of luxury, such as feelings of inauthenticity tied to privilege (Goor et al., 2020) or guilt rooted in inequality (Kapferer & Valette-Florence, 2022). Our research expands this important prior work and offers a more holistic and systematic perspective, examining how societal discourse shapes these negative perceptions, how consumers participate in shaming, and how they cope with its effects while maintaining their consumption behavior.

Second, from a psychological standpoint, our research contributes to the literature on coping by illuminating how luxury consumers regulate emotions under stress and social pressure (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). We show how coping strategies protect consumers' self-esteem, in part, by changing their luxury consumption. For example, we show that "quiet luxury" functions not only as a signaling mechanism but also as a self-protecting coping response to luxury shaming. Prior research has found that high-status consumers favor subtle displays over overt logos (Berger & Ward, 2010; de Figueiredo, 2022); our findings suggest this preference may reflect a strategic effort to mitigate social scrutiny and social disapproval.

Finally, this research offers a methodological contribution by contributing to emerging discussions on the use of GenAI in qualitative research (Epp and Humphreys, 2025). While in this study human researchers still carried out many tasks such as developing interview guides and conducting and analyzing the actual interviews, we see opportunities to delegate parts of these tasks to GenAI as well. Thus, our work not only responds to calls for methodological innovation in consumer research (Lund et al., 2023; Mou et al., 2024; Park et al., 2024) but also paves the way for further integrating GenAI into qualitative research.

### 8.2. Future research

This research has limitations that should be addressed in future studies. First, while we explored how consumers engage in shaming, future research should investigate the underlying motivations or regulatory mechanisms of shaming others. Such behavior may be linked to factors such as low self-esteem, a wish to feel morally superior, or an effort to influence others. Looking into these possible drivers could give a clearer picture of what leads people to shame others over luxury consumption. In addition, future studies should explore the interactive dynamics between shamers and the shamed. In our study, participants responded by assuming both roles; subsequent research could examine these roles separately or as part of a dyad of friends or acquaintances, potentially using longitudinal designs to understand how shaming unfolds as an interactive process. This could also clarify how a shamer's motivations and actions shape the coping strategies of the shamed, and how these patterns evolve.

Furthermore, scholars should examine the conditions under which consumers adopt different coping strategies and how they might affect marketplace behaviors. Some may shift to quiet luxury or value-based products, while others rely on psychological strategies such as detachment or devaluing the shamer. Importantly, brand-level factors may also influence these responses, as certain luxury brands and their consumers may be more vulnerable to shaming than others. Future research could test how contextual factors—including brand reputation, visibility of purchases, and social media dynamics—affect consumers' vulnerability to critique and the coping strategies they deploy over time (e.g., preference shifts following viral posts or brand scandals).

In addition, gender presents a promising avenue for future inquiry. Our findings suggest that certain content categories of shaming may carry different weight for women and men. For instance, economic shaming often took on a gendered form, with women more frequently criticized for financial dependence or overspending. Future research could explore how gender norms and stereotypes shape luxury shaming and coping, and whether these patterns vary across contexts.

Finally, empirical studies should examine the cultural forces that shape luxury shaming. Cultural characteristics such as collectivism, power distance, and a preference for indirect communication are plausible constructs (Gudykunst et al., 1996; Hofstede, 2001); they may affect when shaming occurs, how it is expressed, and how consumers cope with it. In addition, Bedford and Hwang (2003) distinguish between guilt and shame, where guilt is more prevalent in Western societies and shame in Asian societies. Empirical research should examine whether the two negative emotions can be separated and actually differ across cultures in a luxury shaming context. For instance, guilt-related emotions such as remorse or regret may be more salient in Western settings, whereas shame-related emotions such as embarrassment or humiliation may be more common and consequential in Asian contexts. Comparing Western and Chinese luxury consumers could shed light on these distinctions.

Methodologically, while we used a conservative approach using GenAI personae purely for simulating findings from prior qualitative analyses, future research might move from simulation toward prediction. Recent research shows that personae (or "digital twins') can predict the results of consumer studies, both quantitative and qualitative studies (Peng et al., 2025; Toubia et al., 2025; Yan et al., 2024; Yue et al., 2025). In fact, GenAI as an LLM may be better at predicting qualitative than quantitative findings, especially if personae or digital twins are constructed based on qualitative interviews. When engaging in such research, scholars should be mindful, however, that GenAI is constrained by the training data and LLM architectures, which may embed cultural, gender, and socioeconomic biases and produce "average" or normatively acceptable responses (Huang & Rust, 2025). As a result, insights generated by GenAI may not adequately represent more extreme or marginalized responses. Future work should examine the stability of findings across different models and prompting strategies to see whether they alter the content of luxury shaming responses (Huang & Rust, 2022, 2025).

### 8.3. Managerial implications

This research offers several important managerial implications. One key approach is for luxury companies to provide consumers with viable narratives and justifications that help them cope with potential shaming. By highlighting durability, personal value, and sustainability over conspicuous display, luxury brands can help consumers rationalize their purchases in ways that deflect social scrutiny. Storytelling that highlights heritage and craftsmanship can also build credibility and appeal to consumer connoisseurship (Wang, 2022).

At a broader level, however, more fundamental responses from the luxury industry are required. Greater transparency in pricing, supply chain, and environmental claims can reduce consumer skepticism and reduce defensive coping. Rather than treating sustainability as a tactic, brands should embed measurable and verifiable commitments such as transparent sourcing, circular production models, and substantive cause-related partnerships. Brands can also reposition luxury consumption as a thoughtful investment in artistry, heritage, and craftsmanship, helping consumers counter intellectual shaming and frame luxury appreciation as informed taste rather than status-seeking. Initiatives such as certified pre-owned possessions, repair services, and an emphasis on durability and timelessness further reinforce luxury as a smart, long-term choice rather than one of excess (Sun et al., 2021).

### CRediT authorship contribution statement

**Julia Pueschel:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Software, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Shuyi Hao:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Bernd Schmitt:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Conceptualization.

## Data availability

The authors do not have permission to share data.

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